

INLAND

Georgia

The Quiet Country — A Humanistic Documentary · Overview

12 SELECTED STORIES · W. EUGENE SMITH GRANT IN HUMANISTIC PHOTOGRAPHY · 2026

Georgia is internationally legible through three loud stories — the 2008 war and the occupied lines of Abkhazia and South Ossetia, the recurring Tbilisi protests over the country's European future, and the wine-and-feast tourism brand. All three are loud; all three crowd out the quieter country. INLAND asks one question across every lead: what survived? What persists in the high valleys and a few plains communities that has been absorbed by neither empire, Soviet rule, the market, nor the national brand — and can still be witnessed and photographed today.

We read Georgia through the people who keep its endangered knowledge: the mounted transhumance over the Abano Pass, the defence-tower families of Ushguli, the pre-Christian sun-hymns of Svaneti, the only women's Sufi zikr in the South Caucasus at Duisi, the wine made under the floor of the house, and a 26-century Jewish diaspora down to its last worshippers. The occupation lines and the protests are context, never the lens; the state is never cast as villain.

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The 12 Storylines

The Road in May

The Transhumance over the Abano Pass
THE STORY

Around a tenth of Tusheti's people still live to the rhythm of transhumance, driving sheep — and, ever more rarely, riding the migration on horseback — between the Kakheti lowlands and the high summer grass of Tusheti, climbing and descending the Abano Pass at 2,850 metres, one of the most dangerous roads in the country.

“A road older than the nation, still walked once a year.”

Places: Kakheti → Abano Pass → Tusheti (Omalo) · Sources: Atlas Obscura; National Geographic; RFE/RL (horse migration); Milk Trekker

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows one shepherd family through the spring drive up and the autumn descent — the night camps, the dogs, the pass in cloud — a half-millennium-old movement of animals and people, on a real date. The project's signature recurring image.

HISTORY

02

The Tower and the Byre

The Tower-Keeping Families of Ushguli
THE STORY

Ushguli, at the confluence of the Inguri and Black rivers, is among Europe's highest inhabited places — a UNESCO site of more than 200 medieval koshki defence towers. A handful of families still keep house, byre and a standing tower together; Roland and Gulo Chelidze tend cattle, pigs and horses below the family's keep.

“A house, a fortress and a treasury — the same stone.”

Places: Ushguli · Chazhashi · Upper Svaneti · Sources: UNESCO WHC 709; National Geographic; Atlas Obscura; Museum of Wander

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND spends a winter day with one Ushguli family between the byre and the tower — the stock, the horse transport across roadless country, the tower that was once home, fortress and treasury at once.

ARTS & CULTURE

03

Lile, the Sun Song

The Animist Hymns of Svaneti
THE STORY

Some of the oldest layers of Georgian polyphony are Svan: hymns like Lile — the ancient Svan word for the Sun God — and Kviria carry largely pre-Christian, animist texts that Svans today often re-read through a Christian lens. The Mestia ensemble Riho kept them for over fifty years.

“A hymn to the sun, still sung where the church put its name on it.”

Places: Mestia · Svaneti · Sources: Georgian Chant (Kviria; Svan chant); Chanting.ge; Discogs (Riho)

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND sits a rehearsal with Riho, now directed by Vakhtang Pilpani — three male voices braided into a sun-hymn older than the church, in a Mestia front room as the snow comes down.

The Highest Voice

Gurian Krimanchuli on the Black Sea
THE STORY

On the Black Sea side, Gurian polyphony is the most acrobatic of all Georgian song: above the texture flies the krimanchuli, a high yodel-falsetto of tension and release. In Lanchkhuti, the Turkia family has been central to keeping and teaching the Gurian repertoire.

“The voice goes up where no other voice can follow.”

Places: Lanchkhuti · Guria · Sources: UNESCO ICH 00008; chortownia.org; harmonychroniclesmag.com

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND works a supra table in Guria where a three-part song breaks into the krimanchuli — the voice as a household inheritance, taught father to son across the feast.

The Fire in the Enamel

The Minankari Revival of Tbilisi
THE STORY

Minankari, Georgian cloisonné enamel, reached its height between the 10th and 15th centuries on icons and crosses, then was abandoned for centuries. Over the last two decades Tbilisi artists have revived it by an almost unchanged hand process, centred on the ‘Ornament’ gallery.

“A church technique, abandoned for centuries, back in living hands.”

Places: Tbilisi · the ‘Ornament’ gallery · Sources: NTD; mygeotrip (Minankari; Ornament); georgia.to

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND portraits a master — Thea Gurgenidze among them — laying gold wire into cells and firing colour at the bench: a medieval church technique alive in a living hand, taught to an apprentice.

The Wine Under the Floor

Qvevri & the Marani at Harvest
THE STORY

Georgia’s 8,000 years of winemaking are lived, not marketed, in the marani — the cellar where egg-shaped qvevri are buried to the neck and the wine ferments on its skins through the cold without machinery. The qvevri themselves are still thrown by a few families at Vardisubani.

“The wine is made under the floor of the house, on its own skins.”

Places: Kakheti · Vardisubani · Telavi · Sources: UNESCO ICH 00870; wine.gov.ge; Decanter; winesgeorgia.com

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows a Kakhetian family through rtveli, the harvest — the pressing, the qvevri sealed underground, the feast — and the potter at Vardisubani firing a vessel taller than a man.

The Cheese in the Skin

Tushetian Guda on the Summer Mountain

THE STORY

Tushetian guda is made by herders during the summer transhumance from whole raw milk, matured inside a guda — a whole sheepskin sack — and covered with the felted nabadi burka so it takes the salt evenly. The women run the dairy and the wool; the Alaznistavi cooperative has revived the craft.

“A cheese born in a sheepskin, on a mountain, in summer.”

Places: Tusheti · Alaznistavi cooperative · Sources: EU4Georgia (Alaznistavi); Milk Trekker; Wikipedia (Tushetians)

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND documents a summer dairy hut — milk into skin, the nabadi over the curing room, the pardagi felt carpets — naming a guda maker with the Alaznistavi women.

MYTH & RELIGION

The Mountain's Own Faith

The Shrine Cult of Khevsureti

THE STORY

In Khevsureti people worship at jvari / khati — stone shrines two metres tall, hung with ibex horns and a bell — in a syncretism where, behind the Christian names and candles, the rite is essentially pre-Christian, served by an elected khevisberi, a dasturi, and a ‘hostess of the shrine.’

“Behind the candles and the cross, a faith older than the church.”

Places: Khevsureti · Shatili · Mutso · Sources: Wikipedia (Khevsureti); academia.edu (Khatis Diasakhlisi); khconsult

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND works Atengenoba, the great festival 100 days after Easter: the khevisberi at the horned shrine, the beer brewed on the spot, the offering — at the fortress villages of Shatili and Mutso. Consent-led.

MYTH & RELIGION

The Women Who Sing the Zikr

The Kist Sufi Circle of Pankisi

THE STORY

The Kist of Pankisi descend from Chechens who crossed the mountains in the 1800s and follow the pacifist Sufi path of Kunta-Hajji. Pankisi is the only place in the South Caucasus where women lead the zikr in the mosque — every Friday at the Old Mosque in Duisi — and the elders fear it will fall silent.

“The only place women lead the zikr — and it is going quiet.”

Places: Duisi · Pankisi Gorge · Sources: OC Media; Al Jazeera America; pankisivalley.com

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND photographs the Friday women's circle with consent — the turning chant, the nazms in the Kist tongue, the call for ‘peace in the Caucasus’ — with the Aznash Laaman singers. Ritual, not spectacle; identities protected where asked.

The Saint in the Desert

David Gareja on the Disputed Line
THE STORY

David Gareja is a complex of 19 medieval cave monasteries — some 5,000 cells cut into the Kakheti semi-desert in the 6th century, with 8th–13th-century frescoes including a rare portrait of Queen Tamar. The Soviet-drawn Georgia–Azerbaijan border runs straight through it.

“A 6th-century desert, cut in two by a 20th-century line.”

Places: David Gareja · Udabno · Kakheti · Sources: UNESCO tentative 5224; Advantour; Atlas Obscura; wander-lush.org

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND frames monastic life in the rock against the quiet frontier dispute — a monk on the desert ridge where the boundary meets the painted caves. Tension, not attack; verify border access first.

LOCAL COMMUNITIES

11

The Granary Language

Svan, Dying at Home, Sung by the Young
THE STORY

Svan — an unwritten Kartvelian language perhaps three millennia diverged from Georgian — is endangered, spoken by a shrinking number of elders, even as Svan music enjoys a youth-led revival driven from Mestia. The songs return to young mouths while the everyday language thins.

“They sing the words their grandparents spoke, and they no longer do.”

Places: Mestia · Ushguli · Svaneti · Sources: Chai Khana; georgianchant.org; UNESCO Atlas of endangered languages

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows young singers of the Lileo ensemble in Mestia — a rehearsal where teenagers sing hymns in a tongue fewer of them speak at home — the old words kept like seed-grain.

LOCAL COMMUNITIES

12

2,600 Years of Welcome

The Last Worshippers of Oni & Kutaisi
THE STORY

Jews have lived in Georgia for some 26 centuries, in what is often called the one country where they were never persecuted as Jews. The Oni synagogue (1895) once held over a thousand; today fewer than 20 worship there. Kutaisi’s Jewish quarter, once 30,000 strong, counts fewer than a hundred families.

“A synagogue built for a thousand, kept by twenty.”

Places: Oni (Racha) · Kutaisi · Sources: Wikipedia (Oni; Kutaisi synagogues); Gil Travel; jguideeurope.org

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND documents a Sabbath where the minyan is barely made, in a synagogue built for a thousand — the keepers of one of the world’s oldest diasporas, with discretion.

Production Tracks

The Eastern Highlands

STORIES 01 + 07 + 08 + 09

From a Kakheti base: the Abano-Pass transhumance and Tushetian guda cheese, the shrine cult of Khevsureti at Atengenoba, and the women's Sufi zikr of Pankisi. One eastern deployment across the high summer.

Geography: Kakheti (Telavi/Akhmeta) → Tusheti → Khevsureti → Pankisi (Duisi)
Season: Transhumance May & Sept; Atengenoba ~mid-Jul; guda Jun–Sep; zikr Fri
4 stories, 1 eastern base

The Western Voices

STORIES 02 + 03 + 04 + 11 + 12

The west and the high north-west: the tower families and animist sun-hymns of Svaneti, the endangered Svan language sung by the young, the Gurian krimanchuli of Lanchkhuti, and the last Jewish worshippers of Oni and Kutaisi.

Geography: Mestia/Ushguli (Svaneti) → Lanchkhuti (Guria) → Oni (Racha) → Kutaisi
Season: Svaneti late spring–autumn; rehearsals & Sabbaths year-round
5 stories, 1 western loop

The Plain & the Desert

STORIES 05 + 06 + 10

Tbilisi and the Kakhetian plain: the minankari enamel revival, the qvevri marani at harvest, and the cave monastery of David Gareja on the disputed desert line. Anchored on rtveli, the autumn harvest.

Geography: Tbilisi → Kakheti (Vardisubani/Telavi) → David Gareja (Udabno)
Season: Rtveli late Sep; enamel year-round; Gareja spring/autumn light
3 stories, autumn window

A Humanistic Project, in Smith's Tradition

THE APPLICANT

An INLAND-commissioned documentary photographer is the named applicant; INLAND is the editorial home that researches, embeds and publishes the work. The Smith Grant's applicant is an individual photographer, and this is INLAND's route.

PAST WORK

INLAND's Georgia edition (Issue 02, 2024) is the prior cohesive body of work — long-form, humanistic, custodian-led — that this project carries deeper, alongside the Faroe Islands and Isole Minori editions.

PROPOSED PROJECT

'The Quiet Country': a year among Georgia's highland custodians — shepherds over the Abano Pass, the tower families of Ushguli, the shrine-priests of Khevsureti, the Pankisi zikr women, the Kakhetian winemakers — edited to up to 40 images.

WHY SMITH

Concerned, compassionate documentary about the human condition, made with named custodians rather than about them: continuity over crisis, dignity over spectacle. The grant underwrites the extended field embedding the work needs.